

BENGALURU RUNNERS

Women's Initiative

Couch to 5K

12-Week Training Programme

1 June – 23 August 2026

Orientation: 31 May 2026 · Race Day: 23 August 2026

About This Programme

This programme is an initiative of the **Bengaluru Runners Women's Initiative**. While open to all, its core purpose is to give women a safe and supportive space to explore long-distance running — to make physical activity a lifestyle habit and to build a community of women who encourage each other at every step. Performance is never the point. Participation and joy are.

PROGRAMME OVERVIEW

DURATION	12 Weeks 1 June to 20 August 2026
ORIENTATION	31 May 2026 BR Community Run Day — warm-up, cool-down and strength block orientation
SESSIONS	3 per week Solo Session A · Solo Session B · Sunday Group Session
TARGET PARTICIPANT	Absolute Beginner No prior running experience assumed. Zero fitness base is the starting point.
PROGRAMME GOAL	Complete 5K 23 August 2026 — 5K Parkrun. Finish line only. No time target.
APPROACH	Caution first, speed next Moderate progression throughout. Never performance-driven. Consistency is the measure of success.

THE 12-WEEK ARC

PHASE	WEEKS	WHAT HAPPENS
Foundation	1–3	Run/walk intervals. Tendon and ligament conditioning. First 3-min continuous run.
Building Blocks	4–6	Walk breaks shorten. First 5-min then 8-min continuous runs. Week 5 Group: first 10-minute continuous block. ★
Running Emerges	7–9	Continuous runs build from 25 to 35 minutes. Participants begin to enjoy rather than endure.
5K Ready	10–11	Parkrun simulation in Week 10. Week 11 Group: 40 minutes continuous — the longest run of the programme. ★★
Taper	Wk 12	Volume reduces. Legs rest. Race-day logistics briefed. Trust the training.
Race Day	23 Aug	5K Parkrun. Every participant who crosses the finish line wins. The clock is irrelevant.

How to Use This Plan

Session Structure — Each Week

Solo Session A is the first solo session of the week. Participants train independently, following their prescribed run block followed by strength work. All routines are taught at Orientation on 31 May.

Solo Session B follows two days later. It uses a different interval structure from Solo Session A to prevent monotony and allow active recovery between sessions.

Sunday Group Session is the coach-led session and the most important run of the week. It includes a named form drill, the week's peak run challenge, a group interaction moment, and a guided strength block. This is where the community is built.

Effort & Pace Guide

All running in this programme is at a comfortable, conversational pace. If you cannot speak a full sentence while running, you are going too fast. Slow down. There is no such thing as too slow in this programme.

Beginners consistently make the mistake of running faster than necessary. The lungs adapt quickly — the tendons, ligaments, and joints do not. Pace discipline in the first six weeks is what prevents injury in weeks seven through twelve.

- Aim for a pace that feels sustainable for the full prescribed duration — not a sprint, not a stroll.
- Walk intervals are not failures. They are a deliberate part of the training structure.
- Missed a session? Carry on. Missed a full week? Repeat it. Never skip ahead.
- **Stop immediately if:** sharp joint pain, chest tightness, dizziness, or pain that worsens during the run.

Monsoon Advisory — June to August, Bangalore

- Prefer 6–7 AM for solo sessions — heat and rainfall build through the afternoon.
- Avoid mossy tiles and waterlogged footpaths — ankle sprains are the most common monsoon injury for new runners.
- Treadmill is a fully valid substitute on heavy rain days. No session should be skipped for weather alone.
- Hydrate before arriving to sessions — humidity drives sweat even when the temperature feels mild.

Strength & Mobility — Exercise Reference

A strength block follows every run session throughout the programme. Exercises are bodyweight only and require no equipment. The block evolves every three weeks as fitness develops. Sunday Group Sessions introduce each new phase with coaching cues.

PHASE 1 — WEEKS 1 TO 3 · GLUTE ACTIVATION & ANKLE STABILITY

EXERCISE	SETS / REPS	COACHING CUE
Glute Bridge	2 × 12	Drive through heels. Squeeze at the top. Lower back stays neutral — not arched.
Clamshell	2 × 12 / side	Pelvis stays completely still. If the hip rocks backward, the range is too wide.
Standing Calf Raise	2 × 15	2 sec up, 2 sec down. The slow lower phase builds tendon resilience — do not rush it.
Single-Leg Balance	1 × 30 sec	Fix gaze on a fixed point. Progress by closing eyes once stable. Wobbling is normal.

PHASE 2 — WEEKS 4 TO 6 · CORE STABILITY & HIP MOBILITY

EXERCISE	SETS / REPS	COACHING CUE
Dead Bug	2 × 6 / side	Lower back glued to the floor throughout. Move slowly and with full control.
Bird Dog	2 × 8 / side	Opposite arm and leg extend simultaneously. Hips stay level — do not rotate.
Donkey Kick	2 × 12 / side	Drive the heel toward the ceiling. Squeeze the glute at the top. No lower back arch.
Hip Flexor Stretch	1 × 45 sec	Low lunge — back knee on floor, front foot forward. Tuck the pelvis gently.

PHASE 3 — WEEKS 7 TO 11 · FUNCTIONAL LOWER BODY & ROTATIONAL CORE

EXERCISE	SETS / REPS	COACHING CUE
Bodyweight Squat	2 × 12	Feet shoulder-width. Push knees out over toes. Sit back and down — not just down.
Reverse Lunge	2 × 8 / side	Step back, lower the back knee toward the floor. Front shin stays vertical.
Side Plank Hold	2 × 20 sec	Stack feet or stagger. Lift the hip — do not sag.
Hip Circle	1 × 10 each	Hands on hips, draw large slow circles. Full range of motion.
Inchworm	1 × 5 reps	Walk hands to a plank, walk feet to hands. Slow and controlled.

TAPER — WEEK 12 · MOBILITY ONLY, NO STRENGTH LOADING

EXERCISE	SETS / REPS	COACHING CUE
Hip Flexor Stretch	1 × 45 sec	As Phase 2. Hold gently — no pushing.

EXERCISE	SETS / REPS	COACHING CUE
Hip Circle	1 × 10 each	Slow and full range.
Inchworm	1 × 5 reps	Gentle. The work is done.

The 12-Week Programme

Each week shows three sessions. **Solo Session A** and **Solo Session B** are completed independently. The **Sunday Group Session** is coach-led and carries the week's peak challenge. Strength blocks are listed by exercise code — refer to the Exercise Reference on the previous pages.

PHASE 1 — FOUNDATION · Weeks 1 to 3

Theme: Just Show Up · Strength Block: Glute Bridge · Clamshell · Calf Raise · Single-Leg Balance · ~7 minutes

Week 1 · 2 - 8 June

Solo Session A

SOLO A

6 × (Run 1 min / Walk 2 min) · 18 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

6 intervals with generous walk recovery. Focus: completing every interval at a comfortable pace.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

8 × (Run 1 min / Walk 90 sec) · 20 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

More intervals, shorter recovery than Session A. A different challenge on the same run length.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

6 × (Run 90 sec / Walk 2 min) · 21 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Coach calls each interval. Group session — run together.

Game: Match My Pace — one interval at coach pace.

Coach focus: First session together. Get everyone comfortable with the run-walk structure.

Week 2 · 9 - 15 June

Solo Session A

SOLO A

6 × (Run 90 sec / Walk 2 min) · 21 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Run intervals step up to 90 seconds. Keep the same easy conversational pace.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

5 × (Run 2 min / Walk 2 min) · 20 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

First 2-minute continuous runs. Equal run-walk intervals — clean and simple to pace.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

Ladder ×2: (1 min run/1 min walk + 90 sec run/90 sec walk + 2 min run/2 min walk + 90 sec run/90 sec walk) · 24 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down
Run block: ladder structure repeated twice — intervals build then step back down
Coach calls each interval. Debrief: what felt different from Solo Session A?

Coach focus: Second group session. Note who is struggling with the intervals — these are the runners to keep an eye on through Phase 1.

Week 3 · 16 - 22 June

Solo Session A

SOLO A

6 × (Run 2 min / Walk 3 min) · 24 min
Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down
First 2-minute blocks with generous recovery. The longer walk between intervals is intentional — use it fully.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

5 × (Run 3 min / Walk 2 min) · 25 min
Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down
First 3-minute continuous runs. Recovery is now shorter than the run. Trust the pace.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

Full Ladder: 1/1 + 90s/90s + 2/2 + 3/3 + 3/3 + 2/2 + 90s/90s + 1/1 · 30 min
Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down
Ladder builds to a 3-minute peak then mirrors back down — longest session yet.
Group check-in at the end: how did the 3-minute blocks feel?

Coach focus: Phase 1 complete. Celebrate this with the group.

PHASE 2 — BUILDING BLOCKS · Weeks 4 to 6

Theme: Run More, Walk Less · Strength Block: Dead Bug · Bird Dog · Donkey Kick · Hip Flexor Stretch · ~8 minutes · Week 6 is a planned cutback week

Week 4 · 23 - 29 June

Solo Session A

SOLO A

6 × (Run 3 min / Walk 1 min) · 24 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

First 3-minute blocks with short recovery. The 1-minute walk is brief — keep the effort easy so you complete all 6.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

4 × (Run 4 min / Walk 2 min) · 24 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

First 4-minute continuous runs. Fewer intervals, longer blocks — stay at a comfortable pace throughout.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

2 sets of (3 min run / 90 sec walk + 5 min run / 2 min walk + 3 min run) with 60 sec rest between sets · 30 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

60-second standing rest between the two sets — use it fully.

Aim: maintain the same effort in Set 2 as Set 1.

Coach focus: Introduce Phase 2 strength exercises today.

Week 5 · 30 June - 6 July

Solo Session A

SOLO A

Run 5 min / Walk 3 min / Run 5 min / Walk 3 min / Run 5 min · 21 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Three equal 5-minute blocks. Equal recovery. Consistent easy effort throughout.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

Run 8 min / Walk 5 min / Run 8 min · 21 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

First 8-minute continuous runs. Two blocks instead of three — fewer decision points. Generous walk recovery in between.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

★ Run 8 min / Walk 2 min / Run 10 min / Walk 2 min / Run 8 min · 30 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Run block: 8 min / walk 2 min / 10 min / walk 2 min / 8 min.

For the 10-minute block: coach places a marker at the 5-minute point. Runners go out to it and turn back — the turnaround naturally controls pace.

Coach focus: First 10-minute continuous block. Celebrate this milestone.

Week 6 · 7 - 13 July

Solo Session A

SOLO A

CUTBACK WEEK · Run 5 min / Walk 2 min / Run 5 min / Walk 2 min / Run 5 min · 15 min run

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Deliberately lighter than last week. Three easy 5-minute blocks. Effort should feel almost too comfortable — that is the point.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

CUTBACK WEEK · Run 8 min / Walk 3 min / Run 7 min · 15 min run

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Short, easy, and restorative. Let the body absorb five weeks of training before Phase 3 begins.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

CUTBACK WEEK · 20 min easy continuous run

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Easy 20 minutes. No new challenge this week.

Group check-in: how do legs feel compared to Week 5?

Coach focus: Recovery week. Phase 3 begins next week.

PHASE 3 — RUNNING EMERGES · Weeks 7 to 9

Theme: *You're a Runner Now* · Strength Block: *Squat · Reverse Lunge · Side Plank · Hip Circle · Inchworm* · ~10 minutes

Week 7 · 14 - 20 July

Solo Session A

SOLO A

Run 15 min / Walk 2 min / Run 8 min · 25 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Longer first block, shorter second — use the walk as a genuine reset before the final 8 minutes.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

Run 18 min / Walk 2 min / Run 5 min · 25 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

The bulk of the session is in the opening 18 minutes. Keep the effort easy and even throughout.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

Run 22 min / Walk 2 min / Run 6 min at a gentle effort lift

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Run 22 min continuous / 2 min walk / 6 min at a gentle effort lift.

Effort lift: slightly more engagement than the main run — not a sprint.

Coach focus: Introduce Phase 3 strength exercises today.

Week 8 · 21 - 27 July

Solo Session A

SOLO A

Run 15 min / Walk 2 min / Run 10 min · 25 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Consolidates what the Week 7 Group session already demonstrated. The 2-minute walk is a brief reset — start the second block at the same easy pace as the first.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

Run 25 min continuous · 25 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

First continuous 25-minute run. Easy effort throughout — this should feel manageable.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

30 min continuous — second half at slightly greater effort than first

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Run the second half with slightly more engagement than the first — pace awareness, not a race.

Coach focus: Group goal-setting: what is each runner's personal goal for 23 August? Note the answers — to be revisited in Week 11.

Week 9 · 28 July - 3 August

Solo Session A

SOLO A

Run 20 min / Walk 2 min / Run 10 min · 32 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Longest solo session yet. Easy effort — the extra length is the challenge, not the pace.

Solo Session B

SOLO B

Run 25 min continuous easy effort · 25 min

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

Intentionally lighter than Session A — preserves legs going into Sunday's peak.

Sunday — Group Session

GROUP

★ 35 min continuous

Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down

35 minutes continuous. Coach sets a water point at approximately halfway.

Phase 3 complete — four weeks to race day. Celebrate this.

Coach focus: Phase 3 complete. Longest run to date. Acknowledge this clearly with the group before they leave.

PHASE 4 — 5K READY · Weeks 10 to 11*Theme: Own the Distance · Strength Block: Same as Phase 3 · Measure distance for the first time***Week 10 · 4 - 10 August****Solo Session A****SOLO A****Run 30 min — track distance covered with GPS watch or app****Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down****Start measuring kilometres, not just time. Note the distance covered for personal awareness.****Solo Session B****SOLO B****Run 35 min — last 5 min at a gentle effort lift****Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down****First 30 minutes easy and comfortable. Final 5 minutes: a gentle pick-up — not a sprint.****Sunday — Group Session****GROUP****Parkrun Simulation (2.5 km out and back) + Strides Introduction****Run block: 2.5 km out-and-back loop run as a mock race. Coach at turnaround.****Introduce strides to the group: what they are, how to run them, and why they benefit runners.****Practice session: 3-4 strides of 80-100m.***Coach focus: Revisit each runner's Week 8 personal goal.***Week 11 · 11 - 17 August****Solo Session A****SOLO A****Run 30 min easy + 5 strides of 100 m****Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strides · Strength block · Cool-down****Complete the 30-minute easy run, then walk 60-90 seconds, then run 5 strides of 100m.****Walk 60-90 seconds after the easy run, then run 5 strides of 100m. Walk back to recover between each.****Solo Session B****SOLO B****Run 35 min — last 5 min at a gentle effort lift****Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down****The first 30 minutes are easy and relaxed. The final 5 minutes: a gentle pick-up, not a race.****Sunday — Group Session****GROUP****★★ 40 min continuous — time on feet****Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strength block · Cool-down****40 minutes continuous at a comfortable, sustainable pace.****Time on feet — not distance, not speed.***Coach focus: Longest run of the programme. Every runner who completes this is ready for 23 August. Celebrate it.*

PHASE 5 — TAPER · Week 12*Theme: Trust the Training · Mobility only — no strength loading this week***Week 12 · 18 - 23 August****SOLO A****Run 20-22 min easy — the most relaxed run of the entire programme****Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Mobility only (Hip Flexor Stretch · Hip Circle · Inchworm) · Cool-down****The fitness is banked. This session is about freshness, not load.****SOLO B****Run 15 min easy + 5 strides of 60-70 m****Pre-run warm-up · Run block · Strides · Mobility only · Cool-down****Complete the easy run, then walk 90 seconds, then run 5 smooth strides of 60-70m.****This is the last training session before race day. Legs should feel fresh, not worked.***Friday 21 August — Full rest. No running, no strength work.**Saturday 22 August — 10-minute gentle walk only. Lay out full race kit the night before. Early sleep.*

RACE DAY — Sunday 23 August 2026 · 5K Parkrun

60 min before	Light familiar breakfast — banana, toast, idli. Nothing new on race day.
30 min before	Arrive at venue. Collect bib. Easy walk around the course.
15 min before	5-minute easy jog + dynamic drills: leg swings, hip circles, arm circles.
Start line	Line up mid-to-back pack. Adrenaline will want you to go fast. Do not listen to it.
Km 1	Run slower than feels right. The first kilometre lies to everyone.
Km 2-4	Settle into your training pace — the one your body already knows.
Final 500 m	If there is anything left in the tank, use it here.
Finish line	You did it.

The only bad 5K is the one you talked yourself out of. Whatever the clock says — it counts.

Bengaluru Runners Women's Initiative · Couch to 5K 2026

Run together. Grow together.